SUSHIHEY PRESENTS

The Ultimate Sushi Guide

A Japanese Local's Complete Handbook

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Written by a Japanese Local

Not a tourist. Not a food blogger. A real local.

1. Introduction

Welcome. My name is not important, but what matters is this: I am Japanese. I was born and raised in Japan, and I have been eating sushi since before I could properly hold chopsticks. This is not another travel blog post written by someone who visited Tokyo for a week. This is the real thing.

Every year, millions of visitors come to Japan and eat sushi. Most of them make the same mistakes. They drown their nigiri in soy sauce. They mix wasabi into their shoyu dish like it is soup. They skip the extraordinary seasonal fish in favor of salmon, because it is the only name they recognize. They miss out on 90% of what sushi has to offer.

I wrote this guide to fix that.

Inside these pages, you will find everything I wish someone had told me if I were visiting Japan for the first time with fresh eyes: the 30+ fish and toppings you need to know, what is in season and when, how to behave at the counter without embarrassing yourself, how to order in Japanese with correct pronunciation, and how to find incredible sushi at every budget -- from a Y1,000 conveyor belt lunch to a Y50,000 omakase experience in Ginza.

This is your insider passport to the world of real Japanese sushi. Let us begin.

2. Sushi 101: What Sushi Really Is

Most people outside Japan think sushi means "raw fish." It does not. The word "sushi" actually refers to the vinegared rice -- the *shari* or *sumeshi*. Without properly seasoned rice, there is no sushi. A master sushi chef will tell you that the rice is 70% of the craft. The fish is important, but the rice is the soul.

The history of sushi stretches back over a thousand years. The original form, *narezushi*, was fermented fish preserved in rice -- the rice was discarded and only the fish was eaten. This ancient technique still survives in Shiga Prefecture's famous *funazushi*, made with crucian carp from Lake Biwa. The flavor is intensely pungent and an acquired taste even for most Japanese people.

The sushi we know today -- *Edomae-zushi* -- was born in Edo (old Tokyo) in the early 19th century. Street vendors began placing slices of fresh fish from Tokyo Bay on top of hand-pressed vinegared rice, creating a quick, affordable meal for busy merchants and workers. This was the original fast food.

The rice itself is a precise science. Sushi chefs use short-grain Japanese rice (*Japonica*), cook it slightly firm, and season it with a mixture of rice vinegar, sugar, and salt. The exact ratio is each chef's closely guarded secret. The rice must be served at body temperature -- never cold from a refrigerator, never hot from the cooker. When you place a piece of nigiri in your mouth, the rice should gently fall apart, each grain distinct yet cohesive. That moment of dissolution is what separates extraordinary sushi from ordinary sushi.

Temperature, texture, seasoning, timing -- sushi is minimalism perfected.

3. Types of Sushi

Understanding the main forms of sushi will help you navigate any menu in Japan with confidence.

Nigiri-zushi

The most iconic form. A small mound of vinegared rice shaped by hand, topped with a slice of fish or other ingredient. In high-end restaurants, the chef may brush the topping with nikiri (a soy-based glaze) or sprinkle it with sea salt and citrus, meaning you eat it as-is without dipping. Nigiri is the purest expression of the sushi chef's art -- the balance between rice and topping, the temperature, the pressure of the hand-shaping.

Maki-zushi (Rolls)

Rice and filling wrapped in nori (seaweed). *Hosomaki* are thin rolls with a single filling -- tuna, cucumber, or pickled radish. *Futomaki* are thick rolls packed with multiple ingredients. In Japan, maki are simple and elegant. The American-style inside-out rolls loaded with cream cheese and deep-fried shrimp are virtually nonexistent here.

Temaki (Hand Rolls)

A cone of nori filled with rice, fish, and vegetables. Temaki must be eaten immediately -- within 30 seconds of assembly -- before the nori loses its crispness. Many sushi bars serve temaki as a final course because of its casual, fun nature.

Chirashi-zushi

A bowl of sushi rice topped with an assortment of sashimi and garnishes. This is an excellent choice for lunch: it is filling, showcases variety, and is usually priced more affordably than a set of nigiri. Every region of Japan has its own chirashi style.

Sashimi

Technically not sushi, since there is no rice. Sashimi is simply sliced raw fish, served with soy sauce, wasabi, and often garnished with shredded daikon radish and shiso leaf. Ordering sashimi alongside your sushi is a very Japanese thing to do.

Oshi-zushi (Pressed Sushi)

A specialty of Osaka. Rice and toppings are pressed into a rectangular mold (*oshibako*), then sliced into neat blocks. *Battera* (pressed mackerel sushi) is the most famous variety. The texture is denser and more compact than nigiri, and the flavors are often marinated or cured rather than raw.

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4. The Complete Fish & Topping Guide

This is the heart of the book. Know these 30 items and you will be able to navigate any sushi restaurant in Japan -- from a neighborhood conveyor belt to a Michelin-starred counter.

Maguro (Tuna) -- The King of Sushi

Akami (Lean Tuna)

The deep red, lean cut from the back of the bluefin tuna. Akami has a clean, iron-rich flavor with a firm, meaty texture. It is the most traditional cut of tuna in Edomae sushi and remains the benchmark by which many chefs are judged. In the old days, akami was the prized part; fatty tuna was considered inferior and often discarded. High-quality akami from *hon-maguro* (Pacific bluefin) is rich, complex, and anything but boring. Do not skip it in favor of toro -- you will miss the essence of what tuna truly tastes like.

Chutoro (Medium Fatty Tuna)

The marbled belly section between akami and otoro. Chutoro strikes the perfect balance: it has the clean tuna flavor of akami with a gentle, melting richness from its fat content. Many sushi connoisseurs -- including most Japanese regulars I know -- consider chutoro the finest part of the tuna, superior even to otoro. The fat is present but does not overwhelm. The texture is silky, yielding, and deeply satisfying. If you order only one tuna cut, make it chutoro.

Otoro (Fatty Tuna Belly)

The fattiest, most expensive cut, taken from the lower belly near the head. Otoro is pale pink with heavy marbling and melts instantly on the tongue like butter. It is luxurious and decadent, and one or two pieces are usually enough -- the richness can become cloying. In Japan, otoro commands astronomical prices at the Toyosu tuna auction, sometimes exceeding Y10,000 per piece at top restaurants. A must-try, but savor it in moderation.

Sake (Salmon)

Salmon is the most popular sushi topping worldwide, but here is a secret most visitors do not know: salmon was not traditional in Japanese sushi. It only became mainstream in the 1980s and 1990s, largely through Norwegian marketing efforts. Many old-school Edomae sushi chefs still do not serve it. That said, high-quality salmon -- especially from Hokkaido -- is genuinely delicious: buttery, mild, and approachable. If you love salmon, enjoy it, but do not let it be the only thing you order. The ocean has so much more to offer.

Hamachi (Young Yellowtail)

Hamachi is farm-raised young yellowtail with a rich, buttery flavor and a smooth, yielding texture. It is a crowd-pleaser and a staple at virtually every sushi restaurant. The fat content is high, making it satisfying and easy to enjoy. Wild yellowtail changes name as it grows -- *wakashi*, *inada*, *warasa*, and finally *buri* -- and the flavor deepens and fattens with age and season. Winter *buri* is one of Japan's greatest seasonal delicacies.

Uni (Sea Urchin)

Uni is the gonads of the sea urchin, and it is one of the most polarizing items in sushi. Fresh, high-quality uni -- especially *murasaki uni* from Hokkaido -- is creamy, sweet, and oceanic with a custard-like texture that dissolves on the tongue. Bad uni tastes bitter, metallic, and overwhelmingly fishy. The gap between good and bad uni is wider than any other sushi item. If you have tried uni abroad and hated it, please try it again in Japan. It may be a completely different experience. Hokkaido uni, particularly from Rebun and Rishiri islands, is considered the finest in the world.

Ikura (Salmon Roe)

Those glistening orange orbs that pop in your mouth with a burst of briny, slightly sweet liquid. Ikura is cured in soy sauce (*shoyu-zuke*) or salt, and is typically served as *gunkan-maki* -- a small rice ball wrapped in a strip of nori with the roe piled on top. The best ikura appears in autumn when the salmon run upstream. Fresh autumn ikura has thinner membranes and a more delicate pop. Hokkaido ikura is legendary.

Ebi (Shrimp) -- Three Varieties

Amaebi (Sweet Shrimp)

Small, raw cold-water shrimp with a remarkable natural sweetness and a soft, almost creamy texture. Amaebi is typically served raw as nigiri, and the heads are often deep-fried and served alongside as a crunchy bonus -- do not skip them. The sweetness intensifies a day after catch, which is why amaebi is one of the few sushi items that benefits from slight aging.

Botan Ebi (Botan Shrimp)

Larger than amaebi, with a firmer texture and an even more pronounced sweetness. Botan ebi is plump, translucent, and absolutely luxurious. It is less common and more expensive than amaebi, often found at mid-to-high-end establishments. The texture has a satisfying snap that amaebi lacks.

Kuruma Ebi (Tiger Prawn)

The only shrimp traditionally served cooked in Edomae sushi. Kuruma ebi is briefly boiled, butterflied, and pressed onto rice. The flavor is clean, sweet, and delicate -- the hallmark of old-school Tokyo sushi. A good sushi chef's kuruma ebi preparation reveals their technical skill.

Ika (Squid)

Ika is one of the most underrated sushi toppings among foreign visitors, but it is beloved by Japanese sushi regulars. The texture ranges from tender to pleasantly chewy depending on the species and preparation. *Sumi-ika* (golden cuttlefish) is the Edomae classic, prized for its sweetness and soft bite. The chef often scores the surface with fine knife cuts (*kakushi-boucho*) to enhance tenderness and help the squid cling to the rice. Subtle, elegant, and deeply rewarding.

Tako (Octopus)

In Japanese sushi, octopus is almost always served boiled (*yude-tako*). The preparation is crucial: properly cooked tako is tender with a gentle resistance, slightly sweet, and clean-tasting. Overcooked tako becomes rubbery and flavorless. Some high-end restaurants now serve raw octopus (*nama-tako*), which has a completely different character -- slippery, translucent, and surprisingly sweet. Hokkaido's *mizudako* (giant Pacific octopus) is especially prized for raw preparations.

Kohada (Gizzard Shad)

Kohada is the litmus test of an Edomae sushi chef. This small, silvery fish is cured in salt and vinegar -- the *shimemono* technique -- and the degree of curing reveals the chef's philosophy and skill. Too much vinegar and the fish is harsh; too little and it tastes plain. Perfect kohada is bright, tangy, and complex, with a beautiful silver-skinned presentation. Japanese sushi connoisseurs often judge a restaurant by its kohada before anything else. Order it first.

Anago (Saltwater Eel)

Do not confuse anago with unagi (freshwater eel). Anago is lighter, more delicate, and is a cornerstone of traditional Edomae sushi. It is simmered in a sweet soy broth (*nitsume*), then brushed with a reduction of the same liquid, creating a glossy, lacquered finish. The texture should be melt-in-your-mouth tender. Great anago literally dissolves on the rice. Tokyo Bay anago has been famous for centuries, and it remains one of the most satisfying ways to end a sushi meal.

Hotate (Scallop)

Fresh raw hotate is sweet, clean, and has a wonderful creamy texture that almost mimics butter. Hokkaido scallops are world-famous for their size and quality. In sushi, hotate is served as a thick medallion atop rice, sometimes with a brush of citrus or a pinch of salt. The sweetness is natural and needs almost no embellishment. Hotate is also excellent lightly seared (*aburi*) -- the heat caramelizes the sugars and adds a smoky dimension.

Aji (Horse Mackerel)

Aji is one of Japan's most beloved everyday fish, and it shines as sushi. The flavor is clean and slightly oily with a gentle fishiness that is never overwhelming. Fresh aji has a wonderful snap to its texture. It is typically served with grated ginger and sliced scallion rather than wasabi -- the ginger cuts the natural oils beautifully. Aji is abundant, affordable, and a perfect gateway into the world of *hikari-mono* (silver-skinned fish). Available almost year-round but best in early summer.

Engawa (Flounder Fin Muscle)

Engawa is the thin strip of muscle that runs along the fin of a flounder or halibut. It is fatty, crunchy, and rich -- a unique textural experience unlike anything else in sushi. The flavor is concentrated and buttery. Engawa from wild *hirame* (Japanese flounder) is rare, expensive, and exquisite. The more common and affordable version comes from *karei* (halibut), typically imported. Both are worth trying, but if you see *hirame no engawa* on the menu, order it without hesitation.

Tai (Sea Bream)

Tai is considered the king of white-fleshed fish in Japan and holds deep cultural significance -- it is the fish of celebration, served at weddings and New Year. The flavor is clean, refined, and subtly sweet with a delicate firmness. In Edomae tradition, tai is often served with a light *kobujime* treatment (pressed between sheets of kelp) to concentrate the umami. Spring tai -- known as *sakura-dai* -- is the most prized, coinciding with cherry blossom season. An elegant, sophisticated choice.

Saba (Mackerel)

Saba is rich, bold, and intensely flavorful -- the opposite of subtle. In sushi, it is always cured with salt and vinegar (*shime-saba*), which firms the flesh and tempers the strong oils. Good shime-saba is electric: tangy, fatty, and deeply savory. Saba from Oita Prefecture (*Seki-saba*) is considered the finest. Autumn saba, fattened for winter, is particularly spectacular. This is a polarizing fish -- some people find it too strong -- but it is quintessentially Japanese.

Iwashi (Sardine)

Iwashi as sushi is a revelation for people who think they dislike sardines. Served fresh and raw -- not canned, not grilled -- iwashi is delicate, mildly oily, and surprisingly sweet. It is typically garnished with ginger and scallion. Iwashi is fragile and must be consumed very fresh, so finding it at a sushi counter means the fish was likely sourced that morning. It is humble, inexpensive, and wonderful. Peak season is summer to early autumn.

Sanma (Pacific Saury)

Sanma is the iconic taste of Japanese autumn. When this slender, silver fish appears on menus in September and October, Japanese people celebrate the arrival of fall. As sushi, sanma is served raw or lightly seared, often with a squeeze of citrus and a dab of ginger. The flavor is rich, slightly bitter, and complex -- very much an adult taste. Sanma has become increasingly scarce due to overfishing, making it more precious each year. If you visit Japan in autumn and see sanma sushi, do not miss it.

Hirame (Japanese Flounder)

Hirame is one of the premier white-fleshed fish in Edomae sushi. The texture is firm and slightly chewy with a clean, delicate sweetness. Unlike many white fish that can taste bland to the uninitiated, hirame has a quiet depth that reveals itself slowly. Winter hirame is fattier and more flavorful. The chef may serve it with a thin line of wasabi between the fish and rice, or with a touch of sea salt and sudachi citrus. Refined and understated -- a connoisseur's choice.

Kanpachi (Greater Amberjack)

Kanpachi is the leaner, more refined cousin of hamachi. The texture is firmer, the flavor cleaner, and the fat content lower. If hamachi is rich and indulgent, kanpachi is elegant and restrained. It has a beautiful translucency when sliced and a pleasant crunch to the bite. Kanpachi is at its best in summer, making it a perfect warm-weather choice. Many Japanese sushi enthusiasts prefer kanpachi to hamachi for its subtlety.

Shima-aji (Striped Jack)

Shima-aji is a luxury fish that sits between hamachi and kanpachi in richness. The flavor is refined, moderately fatty, and wonderfully complex. Wild shima-aji is rare and expensive -- one of the most prized fish in Japanese sushi. The texture is firm with a satisfying bite, and the aftertaste is clean and lingering. If you see wild (*tennen*) shima-aji on a menu, it is worth the premium. Farm-raised versions are more common and still excellent, though less complex.

Sayori (Halfbeak)

Sayori is a delicate, slender fish with translucent flesh and a subtle, clean flavor. It is one of the harbingers of spring in Japanese sushi -- when sayori appears, winter is ending. The texture is light and slightly firm, and the taste is gentle and refreshing. Sayori is a *hikari-mono* but much milder than kohada or saba. It is often served with a shiso leaf or a tiny dab of ume (plum paste). A beautiful, seasonal choice that shows your appreciation for the finer points of sushi.

Tsubugai (Whelk)

Tsubugai is a sea snail with a distinctive crunchy texture and a sweet, briny flavor. It is served raw, sliced thin, and has a satisfying snap when you bite through it. The crunch is unique in the sushi world -- nothing else has quite this texture. Tsubugai is mild and approachable, making it a good introduction to shellfish sushi. It is available year-round but best in winter and spring.

Akagai (Ark Shell)

Akagai is one of the most visually striking sushi items -- its flesh is a vivid red-orange, almost like a flower petal. The flavor is bright, clean, and mildly metallic with a pleasant chewiness. Akagai is a traditional Edomae item and requires expert preparation: the clam must be carefully cleaned, the hinge removed, and the flesh butterflied. Good akagai has a refreshing quality, almost like biting into the ocean itself. Spring is the prime season.

Mirugai (Geoduck Clam)

Mirugai -- sometimes called the "giant clam" -- has a remarkably crisp, crunchy texture and a sweet, clean ocean flavor. Each piece has a satisfying snap that is addictive. Mirugai is a premium sushi item, usually costing more than standard shellfish. The freshness is everything: when it is fresh, mirugai is extraordinary; when it is not, it becomes rubbery and bland. High-end sushi bars often serve it with just a touch of salt and lemon.

Awabi (Abalone)

Awabi is the most luxurious shellfish in Japanese cuisine. The texture is dense, firm, and slightly chewy -- almost like a perfectly cooked steak. The flavor is concentrated sea sweetness with an incredible umami depth. Wild awabi from the Sanriku coast is legendary. In sushi, it can be served raw (with a texture so firm it requires skillful slicing) or steamed, which softens it into a tender, buttery delicacy. Steamed awabi with its own liver sauce is one of the greatest bites in all of Japanese food.

Kazunoko (Herring Roe)

Kazunoko is herring roe -- a solid mass of tiny eggs that forms a single golden block. The texture is its defining feature: a unique, satisfying crunch with each bite, almost like biting into dozens of tiny bubbles simultaneously. The flavor is mild, slightly salty, and briny. Kazunoko is traditionally a New Year's food in Japan, symbolizing fertility and prosperity. In sushi, it is served as nigiri or sometimes wrapped in nori. It is an unusual texture experience that surprises most first-timers.

Shirako (Milt / Cod Sperm Sac)

Let me be honest: shirako is cod sperm sac. Most foreigners recoil at this, and I understand. But shirako is considered a winter delicacy in Japan and commands premium prices at top sushi restaurants. The texture is extraordinarily creamy -- like a warm, savory custard with a hint of ocean. It is typically served lightly seared or in a ponzu sauce. Shirako is rich, decadent, and unlike anything else you will ever eat. If you can set aside the mental barrier, you may discover one of the most luxurious bites in Japanese cuisine. Winter only.

Tamago (Egg)

Tamago -- the sweet, layered Japanese omelet -- may seem humble alongside luxury ingredients like uni and otoro, but it is one of the most important items in a sushi restaurant. In the old tradition, tamago was the first thing a customer would order to judge the chef's skill, because making excellent tamago requires patience, precision, and a refined palate. The best tamago is moist, fluffy, subtly sweet, and tastes of dashi and shrimp. It is cooked in thin layers, folded repeatedly, and served slightly warm. Never skip tamago.

Toro Salmon (Salmon Belly)

The fatty belly section of salmon, equivalent to otoro in tuna. Toro salmon is extremely rich, buttery, and practically melts on contact with your tongue. The fat content is very high, so one or two pieces are usually sufficient. It has become enormously popular in recent years, especially in conveyor belt sushi, where it is often served with a torch sear (*aburi*) and a drizzle of mayonnaise. While not traditional, it is undeniably delicious and has earned its place in the modern sushi canon.

Buri (Adult Yellowtail)

Buri is the mature form of yellowtail, and winter buri -- *kan-buri* -- is one of the great seasonal treasures of Japanese cuisine. The fish fattens dramatically as water temperatures drop, developing a rich, sweet, deeply savory flavor that surpasses hamachi in every way. Toyama Bay's *Himi buri* is the most famous, and when it appears on menus in December through February, Japanese food lovers make pilgrimages. The difference between winter buri and ordinary hamachi is like the difference between aged wagyu and regular beef.

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5. Seasonal Guide: What to Eat and When

Understanding seasonality -- *shun* -- is central to Japanese food culture. The concept of *shun* means eating ingredients at their peak of flavor, which typically coincides with their natural abundance. Eating seasonally is not a trend in Japan; it is tradition, philosophy, and common sense. A great sushi chef builds the menu around what the sea offers each season.

Spring (March - May)

Spring is the season of delicate, light flavors. **Sayori** (halfbeak) arrives first, a harbinger of warmer days. **Tai** (sea bream) is at its peak -- spring tai, called *sakura-dai*, is named for cherry blossom season. **Hotaru-ika** (firefly squid) from Toyama Bay is a

spring-only treasure, tiny and intensely flavorful. **Akagai** (ark shell) is vibrant and fresh. **Torigai** (cockle) appears briefly with its distinctive dark color and sweet taste. Spring sushi is about renewal, subtlety, and anticipation.

Summer (June - August)

Summer brings the *hikari-mono* (silver-skinned fish) into their prime. **Aji** (horse mackerel) is sweet and abundant. **Kanpachi** (greater amberjack) is lean, firm, and refreshing in the heat. **Shima-aji** (striped jack) appears at its best. **Uni** (sea urchin) from Hokkaido enters peak season. **Anago** (saltwater eel) is tender and light. Summer sushi leans toward clean, vibrant flavors that provide refreshment rather than richness.

Autumn (September - November)

Autumn is arguably the greatest sushi season. **Sanma** (Pacific saury) arrives in September, signaling fall. **Ikura** (salmon roe) reaches peak quality as salmon return to rivers. **Saba** (mackerel) fattens for winter and becomes intensely rich. **Katsuo** (bonito) returns for its second season -- *modori-katsuo* -- fattier and richer than spring's first run. **Kohada** and virtually every fish begin to develop deeper flavors as the water cools.

Winter (December - February)

Winter is the season of richness and luxury. **Buri** (adult yellowtail) reaches its apex -- *kan-buri* is extraordinary. **Hirame** (flounder) fattens and becomes silky. **Tara** (cod) and its prized **shirako** (milt) appear. All three cuts of **maguro** (tuna) are at their richest. **Amaebi** (sweet shrimp) from the Sea of Japan is at peak sweetness. Winter sushi is bold, rich, and deeply satisfying -- the sea's answer to the cold.

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6. Sushi Etiquette: How to Eat Like a Local

Hands vs. Chopsticks

Both are acceptable. In Japan, eating nigiri with your hands is traditional and perfectly polite, even at high-end restaurants. Many regular Japanese customers use their hands at the counter and chopsticks at a table. Do whichever feels comfortable. For sashimi, always use chopsticks.

Soy Sauce

The cardinal rule: dip the fish side, not the rice side. Turning the nigiri upside down and lightly touching the fish to the soy sauce prevents the rice from absorbing too much and falling apart. At high-end restaurants, the chef often seasons each piece with nikiri (a soy-based glaze), salt, or citrus -- in that case, no soy sauce is needed. When the chef says nothing, a light dip is fine.

Wasabi

Real wasabi (*hon-wasabi*) is freshly grated at good restaurants and has a gentle heat that dissipates quickly -- completely different from the horseradish paste at cheap places. The chef places wasabi between the fish and rice. Do not mix wasabi into your soy sauce -- this is the most common faux pas foreigners commit. It dulls the wasabi's fragrance and over-seasons the soy sauce. If you want extra wasabi, ask the chef politely.

Gari (Pickled Ginger)

Gari is a palate cleanser between different types of fish. It is not a topping -- do not place it on your sushi. Eat a slice between pieces to reset your taste buds. The ginger should be thin, lightly sweet, and refreshing.

Timing

Eat each piece soon after it is placed before you. Sushi is served at an intentional temperature -- the warm rice, the cool fish -- and this balance fades quickly. Letting sushi sit while you take photographs or finish a conversation is, frankly, a waste of the chef's craft. One piece, one bite, immediate consumption. That is the ideal.

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7. Restaurant Types: Where to Eat Sushi in Japan

Kaiten-zushi (Conveyor Belt Sushi)

Plates of sushi travel on a conveyor belt and you grab what appeals to you. Prices are color-coded by plate. Modern chains like Sushiro, Kura Sushi, and Hamazushi use touch-screen ordering systems. Do not underestimate kaiten-zushi -- the quality at top chains has improved dramatically. A satisfying meal costs Y1,000 to Y3,000 per person. Perfect for families, solo diners, and anyone wanting variety without formality.

Counter Sushi (Sushi-ya)

A traditional sushi restaurant where you sit at a counter facing the chef. The chef prepares each piece by hand in front of you. This is the quintessential sushi experience. Prices range from Y3,000 to Y15,000 for a meal. Neighborhood sushi-ya are often the best value in Japan -- find one with a friendly chef and you will eat better than at many famous restaurants.

Tachi-gui (Standing Sushi)

Stand-up sushi bars, often found near train stations and in market areas. You eat at a counter while standing. Tachi-gui is fast, casual, and surprisingly good -- the turnover is high, meaning the fish is often very fresh. Prices are typically displayed per piece. A quick lunch can cost as little as Y800 to Y2,000. This is how many Tokyo businesspeople eat sushi on a weekday.

Omakase (Chef's Choice)

You place yourself entirely in the chef's hands. The chef selects the best ingredients of the day and serves a curated progression of courses, typically 10 to 20 pieces plus appetizers. Omakase ranges from Y10,000 at mid-range restaurants to Y30,000-Y50,000+ at top establishments. This is sushi as a performance -- each piece tells a story of the season, the sea, and the chef's vision.

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8. How to Order in Japanese: 20 Essential Phrases

You do not need to speak Japanese to eat sushi in Japan, but knowing a few phrases will dramatically improve your experience. Chefs and staff genuinely appreciate the effort.

1. **Sumimasen** (su-mi-ma-sen) -- "Excuse me" -- Use to get the chef's attention

2. **Omakase de onegaishimasu** (o-ma-ka-se de o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "Chef's choice, please"

3. **Okonomi de onegaishimasu** (o-ko-no-mi de o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "I'll order piece by piece, please"

4. **Kore wa nan desu ka?** (ko-re wa nan des-ka) -- "What is this?"

5. **Osusume wa nan desu ka?** (o-su-su-me wa nan des-ka) -- "What do you recommend?"

6. **Kyou no osusume wa?** (kyoh no o-su-su-me wa) -- "What's today's recommendation?"

7. **[item] kudasai** ([item] ku-da-sai) -- "Please give me [item]"

8. **Mou ikko onegaishimasu** (moh ik-ko o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "One more piece, please"

9. **Agari kudasai** (a-ga-ri ku-da-sai) -- "Green tea, please" (sushi bar term for tea)

10. **Oaiso onegaishimasu** (o-ai-so o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "Check, please"

11. **Ikura desu ka?** (i-ku-ra des-ka) -- "How much is it?"

12. **Oishii desu** (oi-shee des) -- "It's delicious"

13. **Sabi nuki de** (sa-bi nu-ki de) -- "Without wasabi"

14. **Shoyu wa arimasu ka?** (shoh-yu wa a-ri-mas-ka) -- "Do you have soy sauce?"

15. **Nama biiru kudasai** (na-ma bee-ru ku-da-sai) -- "Draft beer, please"

16. **Nihonshu onegaishimasu** (ni-hon-shu o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "Sake, please"

17. **Gochisousama deshita** (go-chi-soh-sa-ma de-shi-ta) -- "Thank you for the meal" (said when leaving)

18. **Otemoto kudasai** (o-te-mo-to ku-da-sai) -- "Chopsticks, please"

19. **Tokujo onegaishimasu** (to-ku-joh o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "Premium grade, please"

20. **Shiage onegaishimasu** (shi-a-ge o-ne-gai-shi-mas) -- "I'd like to finish" (signals end of meal)

Pro tip: At counter sushi, simply saying the fish name followed by *kudasai* is perfectly natural and polite. "Chutoro kudasai" -- that is all you need.

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9. Tokyo Sushi Guide: Where to Go

Tsukiji Outer Market

The famous inner wholesale market moved to Toyosu in 2018, but the outer market (*jogai shijo*) remains -- and it is still fantastic. Dozens of sushi restaurants, seafood stalls, and food shops line the narrow streets. The quality is genuinely good, and the atmosphere is electric, especially in the early morning. Recommended for visitors who want variety, walking-around food, and the historic Tsukiji energy. Go early -- by 7 AM if possible -- and avoid weekends if you can.

Toyosu Market

The new wholesale market, opened in 2018, is modern, clean, and enormous. The famous tuna auction can be viewed from an observation deck (reservations required for close-up viewing). Several excellent sushi restaurants operate inside the market, serving fish that was auctioned just hours earlier. Sushi Dai and Daiwa Sushi, both relocated from Tsukiji, still draw long lines -- arrive by 5 AM to have any chance. Alternatively, less famous shops in the same building serve comparable quality with no wait.

Ginza

Ginza is the spiritual home of high-end Edomae sushi. Legendary restaurants like Sukiyabashi Jiro (made famous by the documentary *Jiro Dreams of Sushi*), Saito, and Harutaka operate here. A meal at these establishments costs Y30,000 to Y50,000+ and typically requires reservations months in advance, often through a hotel concierge. However, Ginza also has many excellent mid-range sushi restaurants in the Y10,000-Y20,000 range that are easier to book and deliver extraordinary quality. Do not assume Ginza means inaccessibly expensive.

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10. Budget Guide: Great Sushi for Y1,000-Y3,000

You do not need to spend a fortune to eat excellent sushi in Japan. Here is how to eat well on a budget:

Conveyor belt chains: Sushiro, Kura Sushi, and Hamazushi offer plates starting at Y100-Y150 (approximately $0.70-$1.00). A full meal of 8-12 plates costs Y1,000-Y2,000. The quality is surprisingly good -- these chains have massive purchasing power and efficient supply chains.

Lunch sets (*ranchi setto*): Many mid-range sushi restaurants offer lunch at 30-50% less than dinner prices. A nigiri set with 8-10 pieces plus miso soup might cost Y1,500-Y3,000 at lunch versus Y5,000+ at dinner.

Standing sushi near train stations: Quick, fresh, and cheap. Many pieces are Y100-Y300 each.

Supermarket sushi: Japanese supermarkets sell sushi packs (*moriawase*) that are genuinely good, especially if you buy them after 6 PM when they are discounted 20-50%. A Y500 supermarket sushi pack in Japan is better than most sushi restaurant meals abroad.

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11. Omakase Guide: Y10,000-Y50,000

Omakase is sushi elevated to a complete dining experience. Here is what to expect:

A typical omakase at a high-end restaurant lasts 60-90 minutes and includes 15-20 courses. It often begins with a few small appetizers (*tsumami*) -- perhaps sashimi, steamed abalone, or a small dish of seasonal vegetables. Then the nigiri progression begins, typically moving from lighter fish (white fish, squid) to richer items (tuna, fatty fish) and ending with tamago and perhaps miso soup.

Price tiers:

- Y10,000-Y15,000: Excellent neighborhood sushi-ya. Outstanding value.
- Y15,000-Y25,000: High-quality establishments, often with exceptional ingredients.
- Y25,000-Y50,000+: Destination restaurants, Michelin-starred, rare ingredients, legendary chefs.

Reservations: Mid-to-high-end restaurants require reservations. Call ahead or ask your hotel concierge. Some restaurants only accept Japanese-speaking reservations. Services like Tableall, Omakase, and Pocket Concierge handle bookings in English.

Etiquette: Arrive on time. Eat what is served. Trust the chef. Express gratitude.

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12. Sake Pairing

Sake and sushi are a natural pairing -- both are expressions of Japanese rice culture. Here are basic guidelines:

Light white fish (tai, hirame, sayori): Pair with *junmai daiginjo* -- light, fragrant, and elegant. Serve chilled.

Rich, fatty fish (otoro, buri, salmon): Pair with *junmai* sake -- fuller-bodied with more umami to match the richness.

Hikari-mono (kohada, saba, aji): Pair with *honjozo* or dry *junmai* -- the acidity complements the vinegar-cured fish.

Shellfish (hotate, uni, akagai): Pair with *daiginjo* -- clean and crisp, letting the shellfish sweetness shine.

General rules: Avoid strongly flavored sake that overpowers the fish. Cold or slightly chilled sake works best with sushi. Beer (especially crisp Japanese lagers like Asahi or Kirin) is also perfectly acceptable and very common.

Pro tip: At omakase restaurants, ask for *sake pairing* -- many chefs now offer curated sake selections matched to each course. This is the best way to experience the synergy.

13. Vegetarian & Plant-Based Options

Sushi is not exclusively about fish. Japan offers more vegetarian sushi options than most people realize:

- **Kappa-maki**: Cucumber roll -- the classic vegetarian sushi
- **Natto-maki**: Fermented soybean roll -- an acquired taste, but beloved in Japan
- **Kanpyo-maki**: Dried gourd roll -- sweet, chewy, and traditional
- **Avocado nigiri/maki**: Widely available at conveyor belt restaurants
- **Tamago**: Sweet egg omelet -- vegetarian (contains egg and dashi)
- **Inari-zushi**: Sushi rice stuffed inside sweet fried tofu pockets
- **Umejiso-maki**: Plum paste and shiso leaf roll -- refreshing and tangy
- **Shinko-maki**: Pickled radish roll -- bright yellow and crunchy
- **Yasai (vegetable) sushi**: Some creative restaurants offer nigiri with roasted tomato, grilled eggplant, or marinated mushrooms

At conveyor belt restaurants, vegetarian options are always available. At counter sushi bars, inform the chef at the beginning of the meal -- most chefs will be happy to accommodate.

14. Glossary: 50+ Essential Sushi Terms

Japanese	Pronunciation	English
Agari	a-ga-ri	Green tea (sushi bar term)
Akami	a-ka-mi	Lean tuna
Chirashi	chi-ra-shi	Scattered sushi bowl

Japanese	Pronunciation	English
Chutoro	choo-to-ro	Medium fatty tuna
Edomae	e-do-ma-e	Tokyo-style sushi
Engawa	en-ga-wa	Flounder fin muscle
Gari	ga-ri	Pickled ginger
Gunkan	gun-kan	Battleship-style sushi (wrapped in nori)
Gyoku / Tamago	gyo-ku / ta-ma-go	Sweet egg omelet
Hikari-mono	hi-ka-ri-mo-no	Silver-skinned fish category
Hon-wasabi	hon-wa-sa-bi	Real wasabi (freshly grated)
Ikura	i-ku-ra	Salmon roe
Itamae	i-ta-ma-e	Sushi chef
Kabuki	ka-bu-ki	Tuna cheek meat
Kampai	kam-pai	Cheers (toast)
Kobujime	ko-bu-ji-me	Kelp-pressed technique
Murasaki	mu-ra-sa-ki	Soy sauce (sushi bar term)
Nakaochi	na-ka-o-chi	Tuna scraped from the bone
Namida	na-mi-da	Wasabi (sushi bar slang, means "tears")
Neta / Tane	ne-ta / ta-ne	Sushi topping
Nigiri	ni-gi-ri	Hand-pressed sushi
Nikiri	ni-ki-ri	Soy-based glaze brushed by chef
Nitsume	ni-tsu-me	Sweet soy reduction (for anago)
Nori	no-ri	Dried seaweed sheet
Okonomi	o-ko-no-mi	Ordering piece by piece
Omakase	o-ma-ka-se	Chef's choice
Oshibako	o-shi-ba-ko	Wooden press mold for oshi-zushi
Otoro	o-to-ro	Fatty tuna belly
Ponzu	pon-zu	Citrus soy sauce
Sabi	sa-bi	Wasabi (abbreviation)

Japanese	Pronunciation	English
Sabi-nuki	sa-bi-nu-ki	Without wasabi
Shari	sha-ri	Sushi rice
Shimemono	shi-me-mo-no	Vinegar-cured fish
Shoyu	shoh-yu	Soy sauce
Shun	shun	Peak season (for ingredients)
Sudachi	su-da-chi	Japanese citrus fruit
Sumeshi	su-me-shi	Vinegared rice
Tane	ta-ne	Topping / ingredient
Temaki	te-ma-ki	Hand roll
Tsumami	tsu-ma-mi	Appetizers (eaten with drinks)
Tsume	tsu-me	Sweet glaze (same as nitsume)
Uni	u-ni	Sea urchin
Wasabi	wa-sa-bi	Japanese horseradish
Yude-tako	yu-de-ta-ko	Boiled octopus
Zuke	zu-ke	Soy-marinated (e.g., zuke maguro)
Aburi	a-bu-ri	Flame-seared
Ama-ebi	a-ma-e-bi	Sweet shrimp
Battera	ba-te-ra	Pressed mackerel sushi (Osaka)
Futomaki	fu-to-ma-ki	Thick roll
Hosomaki	ho-so-ma-ki	Thin roll
Inari	i-na-ri	Fried tofu pocket sushi
Kakushi-boucho	ka-ku-shi-boh-choh	Hidden knife cuts (scoring technique)
Moriawase	mo-ri-a-wa-se	Assorted platter

This guide was written by a Japanese resident with decades of sushi experience. The information reflects genuine insider knowledge, not tourist-oriented generalizations. Eat well, eat seasonally, and respect the craft. Itadakimasu.

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